

Burial Guide

What to do when a death occurs, burial or entombment, and how many death certificates you will need.

Call us first

206-242-1787, any hour of the day or night. That one call is the whole of what has to happen immediately. We bring your loved one into our care, and everything below follows over the next few days with us beside you. If the death was at home under hospice, the nurse will call us for you.

THE FIRST FEW DAYS, IN ORDER

1 Contact Bonney Watson

Call us at **206-242-1787** (available 24/7). We'll arrange to bring your loved one into our care. If the death occurs at home under hospice, the hospice nurse will call us on your behalf.

2 Gather Important Documents

We'll need the decedent's legal name, Social Security number, date of birth, and veteran status. If they have a pre-plan, locate the paperwork. It has most of this information.

3 Meet with Us

We'll set up a time to meet, usually within a day or two. That's where we go through the type of service, the casket, cemetery property, and the rest of the details.

4 Select a Service Date

Most burial services take place 5–10 days after death, allowing time for family to travel and for obituary publication. We coordinate with the cemetery, clergy, and any other parties.

5 Finalize Details

Flowers, music, pallbearers, readings, photo displays, obituary wording: we help with all of it. Take on as much or as little of it as you want to.

BURIAL OR ENTOMBMENT

Traditional Ground Burial

IN-GROUND INTERMENT

The casket is placed in a grave at the cemetery and sealed with a concrete vault. The grave is marked with a flush granite marker or, in select sections, an upright monument.

- Single or companion (side-by-side) spaces available
- Concrete outer burial container required
- Flush marker in most sections; upright in select areas
- Endowment care included, so the grounds are maintained in perpetuity
- Multiple sections with different settings and pricing

Entombment (Mausoleum)

ABOVE-GROUND INTERMENT

The casket is placed in a mausoleum crypt, an above-ground structure with individual sealed compartments. It's what families choose when they'd rather not be in the ground.

- Climate-protected, above-ground resting place
- No outer burial container required
- Engraved granite or bronze faceplate
- Limited availability at Washington Memorial Park
- Single and companion crypts

Most families at Washington Memorial Park choose **traditional ground burial**. The cemetery has over 20 sections, each with a different landscape and price range. We can walk you through what's for sale and help you find the right spot.

THE KINDS OF SERVICE

Viewing and funeral service. A visitation, then a service at a chapel or church, then a procession to the graveside. This is what most people picture. Families choose it when a lot of people will want to come, or when seeing them one last time matters.

Graveside service. Everything happens at the grave itself. Simpler, shorter, and usually smaller.

Memorial service. A service without the casket present, held whenever suits the family rather than in the first week.

Private family burial. Immediate family only, with no public service. Some families follow it with a gathering later.

DEATH CERTIFICATES

A certified death certificate is the official document needed to settle your loved one's affairs, and you will need more copies than you expect. Most families order **8–12**. We file the certificate with the state and order the copies for you. Each certified copy costs **\$25** from the state of Washington, and it is far easier to order enough upfront than to come back for more. Every institution below needs its own; most will not accept a photocopy.

WHO NEEDS A CERTIFIED COPY

- Banks:** each bank, one copy each
- Insurance companies:** life, health, auto
- Social Security Administration**
- VA / military benefits**
- Retirement / pension plans**
- Real estate / title companies**
- Vehicle title transfer (DOL)**
- Attorney / probate court**
- Employer / HR department**
- Credit card companies**

What comes after this

A burial also involves a casket, an outer burial container, and a marker. We carry over 200 caskets from roughly **\$1,130 to \$12,000**, the cemetery requires a concrete outer container for every ground burial, and most sections take a flush granite marker. Each of those has a guide of its own with photographs and prices, and I'm glad to send whichever ones you want. I'd rather give you a real number than a guess. Call or email me and I will put an exact quote in writing, with no obligation.

Martice Morrison · (206) 445-9794 · mmorrison@bonneywatson.com